zühlke
empowering ideas

Designing for

accessibility

Quick do’s and don’ts for seven access needs.

Cognitive

Neurodivergent people
Anxiety

Sensory

Screen reader users
Low vision or colour blindness
Deaf, hard of hearing or non-verbal

Physical

Limited mobility or dexterity
Epilepsy or motion sensitivity

COGNITIVE

Designing for

neurodivergent people

✓ Do...	✕ Don't...
Use calm colours	Use busy, clashing colours
Write short, plain sentences	Write walls of text
Left-align text	Justify, italicise or use CAPS
Let people pause or hide motion	Autoplay video or carousels
Label buttons clearly	Use vague labels like "Click here"

Who this helps

Permanent	Autism, ADHD, dyslexia
Temporary	Migraine
Situational	Noisy office

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Look at the page for five seconds, then look away.
Pass if	You can say what the page is for and what to do next.

COGNITIVE

Designing for people with

anxiety

✓ Do...

- Say how long it takes
- Give enough time
- Confirm what happens next
- Make help easy to find
- Write calm error messages

✕ Don't...

- Surprise people mid-task
- Time out without warning
- End on a vague "Submitted"
- Offer phone-only support
- Blame people: "Invalid!"

Who this helps

Permanent	Anxiety, depression
Temporary	Bereavement
Situational	Urgent deadline

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Start on any page and look for help or contact details.
Pass if	You find it in two clicks or fewer.

SENSORY

Designing for

screen reader users

✓ Do...

- Describe images with alt text
- Use real headings and buttons
- Make it work by keyboard
- Announce errors and updates
- Write descriptive links

✕ Don’t...

- Put information only in images
- Fake them with styling
- Rely on hover or drag
- Change things silently
- Repeat “Read more”

Who this helps

Permanent	Blind
Temporary	After eye surgery
Situational	Listening while driving

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Turn on VoiceOver (Mac) or NVDA (Windows) and listen to the page.
Pass if	It makes sense without looking at the screen.

SENSORY

Designing for people with

low vision or colour blindness

✓ Do...	✕ Don't...
Use strong contrast	Use light grey text
Let text resize and reflow	Break at high zoom
Pair colour with text or icons	Rely on red and green
Keep actions near their content	Spread content across the page
Show a clear focus outline	Hide the focus outline

Who this helps

Permanent	Low vision, colour blindness
Temporary	Cataract
Situational	Screen glare

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Zoom your browser to 400%.
Pass if	All text is readable, with nothing cut off or overlapping.

SENSORY

Designing for people who are

deaf, hard of hearing or non-verbal

✓ Do...	✕ Don't...
Caption video	Put content in audio only
Show alerts visually	Use sound-only alerts
Offer chat or email	Make phone the only option
Offer typing as well as voice	Require voice input
Write in plain language	Use jargon

Who this helps

Permanent	Deaf, non-verbal
Temporary	Ear infection
Situational	Noisy train

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Watch your video with the sound off.
Pass if	Captions and visuals still get the full message across.

PHYSICAL

Designing for people with

limited mobility or dexterity

✓ Do...

- Make targets big
- Space controls apart
- Offer a click instead of a drag
- Allow enough time
- Reduce typing with autofill

✕ Don't...

- Use tiny links and buttons
- Crowd them together
- Require swipes or drags
- Use short time-outs
- Ask for the same details twice

Who this helps

Permanent	Arthritis, tremor
Temporary	Broken wrist
Situational	Holding a baby

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Put the mouse away and use only the keyboard.
Pass if	You can finish the task and always see where you are.

PHYSICAL

Designing for people with

epilepsy or motion sensitivity

✓ Do...

- Keep flashing under 3 per second
- Respect “Reduce motion”
- Let people pause movement
- Keep transitions subtle
- Warn before intense visuals

✕ Don’t...

- Use strobe or flicker
- Force parallax and zoom effects
- Autoplay looping animation
- Animate large areas on scroll
- Surprise people with flashing

Who this helps

Permanent	Epilepsy, vertigo
Temporary	Migraine
Situational	Reading on a moving train

Test it in 2 minutes

Try	Turn on Reduce motion in your device settings and reload.
Pass if	Animations stop or become subtle.